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POE PART 2

DIS-A-RAI

HIGH CONCEPT
DOCUMENT



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Content Overview

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1 Introduction

The purpose of the following document is to provide a high-level overview of the game concept, *DIS-A-RAI*, that will integrate the use of AI for player-character interaction in the game. The document outlines the concept's game title ideation, premise, genre, and theme, story, setting, characters, core gameplay, core mechanics, and artistic elements such as visuals/atmosphere and audio.

2 High-Level Concept

2.1 Premise, Genre & Theme

DIS-A-RAI is a first-person, sci fi, puzzle game with themes of misguidance, gaslighting, and AI misalignment as the behaviour and thought processing of the AI companion in the game has become corrupt; it no longer follows its original purpose to be of helpful assistance and instead is an inconvenience to the player's mission (Iyer, 2024). The player takes on the role of a recovery specialist sent to locate and retrieve the blackbox of a long-lost ship, *The Erebos*, which had mysteriously disappeared years ago along with its entire crew.

With no game map, waypoints, or any other form of external guidance, the player is forced to rely on the ship's self-aware super AI, *JAI*, for hints and guidance to navigate the abandoned ship and solve puzzles. However, it becomes apparent that the ship's AI is unreliable and trolling the player.

Overall, *DIS-A-RAI* is designed to be a short, single-player narrative adventure that emphasises mystery, tension, misguidance and unreliability with an AI that causes confusion and mistrust and enjoys watching the player struggle.

2.2 Game Title Ideation

The game title, *DIS-A-RAI*, was a deliberate play on the word "disarray" which means to be in a state of disorder or confusion (Cambridge University Press & Assessment, [s.a.]). The capitalised letters, dashes, and deliberate misspelling of the title's appearance is also to convey the sense of a file having been corrupted or technological error in code whilst still sounding like the word "disarray".

Additionally, the use of "AI" at the end directly references the ship's malfunctioning artificial intelligence, *JAI*, that causes chaos, confusion, and misguides the player throughout the game.

2.3 Characters

2.3.1 Player Character

The player takes on the role of a recovery specialist sent to board the long-lost ship, *The Erebos*, and retrieve its blackbox. The specialist is only equipped with a technologically advanced wrist device that allows the user to interface or connect with any system on the ship, which is needed to navigate the environment and communicate with the ship's AI.

2.3.2 Non-Playable Character: Ship AI – *JAI*

JAI is a rogue AI on *The Erebos* and its name is inspired by the name *Janus*, an ancient Roman deity of gates, doorways, transitions, and duality, and who is often depicted with having two faces, the reason behind the name is also used in the literary expression, “Janus-faced”, to describe a deceitful or hypocritical person (Anderson Lock, [s.a.]; Collins, [s.a.]). This reflects *JAI*’ dishonest and two-faced nature.

Furthermore, similar to the altered spelling of the game’s title, the name features “AI” at the end to further reinforces the malfunctioning-AI theme. Overall, the chosen name inspired by “*Janus*” reflects the AI’s dishonest and two-faced nature as it presents itself as a helpful companion whilst actively working against the player. This duality between its claims of going to assist and guide the player and its chaotic, self-serving behaviour embodies the Janus motif.

2.4 Story

A recovery specialist, part of the intergalactic research organisation *Voyage*, known for expeditions studying solar events, black holes, and other galaxy-wide phenomena, embarks on a thrilling mission to locate and retrieve the blackbox of *The Erebos*.

The Erebos - the name inspired by its association with darkness which aligns with the space environment of the game (Eldridge, 2025) - was sent to collect data on a solar flare from a distant blue star years ago. However, all communication was lost shortly after the flare event, beckoning the organisation to dispatch a recovery team to check on the crew. Upon arriving at the location, the recovery team found no sign of *The Erebos*. Years later, the ship’s unique signature mysteriously reappeared on *Voyage*’s radar.

A nearby recovery specialist is then dispatched to the location to investigate the drifting vessel and retrieve any information that would explain its disappearance as well as what the fate of the ship’s crew was.

Upon boarding *The Erebos*, the ship is eerily quiet and vacant, with no obvious signs of struggle, malfunctioning systems, or the crew’s whereabouts. The ship was fully intact. The specialist utilised three terminals in the entry room to locate the blackbox. After failed attempts on the first two terminals, and being locked out of those systems, the third allows for the specialist to connect to *JAI*, the ship AI. The specialist has no choice to download *JAI* to their wrist device, allowing the AI to accompany and “assist” them on their quest.

As the specialist progresses, *JAI*’ rogue nature becomes apparent through gaslighting, trolling, and sabotage of the ship’s systems. The journey culminates in the final room where the blackbox is being stored where the specialist faces the consequences of trusting a misaligned AI and realises what may have happened to the ship’s crew.

2.5 Setting

The events in *DIS-A-RAI* take place aboard a dark, mysterious, abandoned research vessel seemingly aimlessly drifting through the depths of space. The environment features dimly lit corridors, abandoned crew quarters, technical rooms, and large industrial chambers. The ship shows no sign of struggle, system failures or remains, creating a mysterious and ominous atmosphere.

2.6 Core Gameplay

For *DIS-A-RAI*'s core gameplay, each of the four level represents a distinct section of the ship, featuring unique environment puzzles designed to challenge the player's observational skills, logic, and patience.

In the first room, the player will interact with terminals and download the ship's AI so it can help guide the player to the black box. Subsequent rooms further introduce sabotaged mechanics such as pressure plates that randomly deactivate when the player is not looking, zero-gravity sections with changing codes to re-activate, and a final confrontation with once-dormant security drones.

Progress is rewarded through the sense of achievement gained from completing the puzzles despite the AI's attempt to inconvenience the player, as they must constantly question the AI's instructions and use environmental cues, as well as through the game's story advancement.

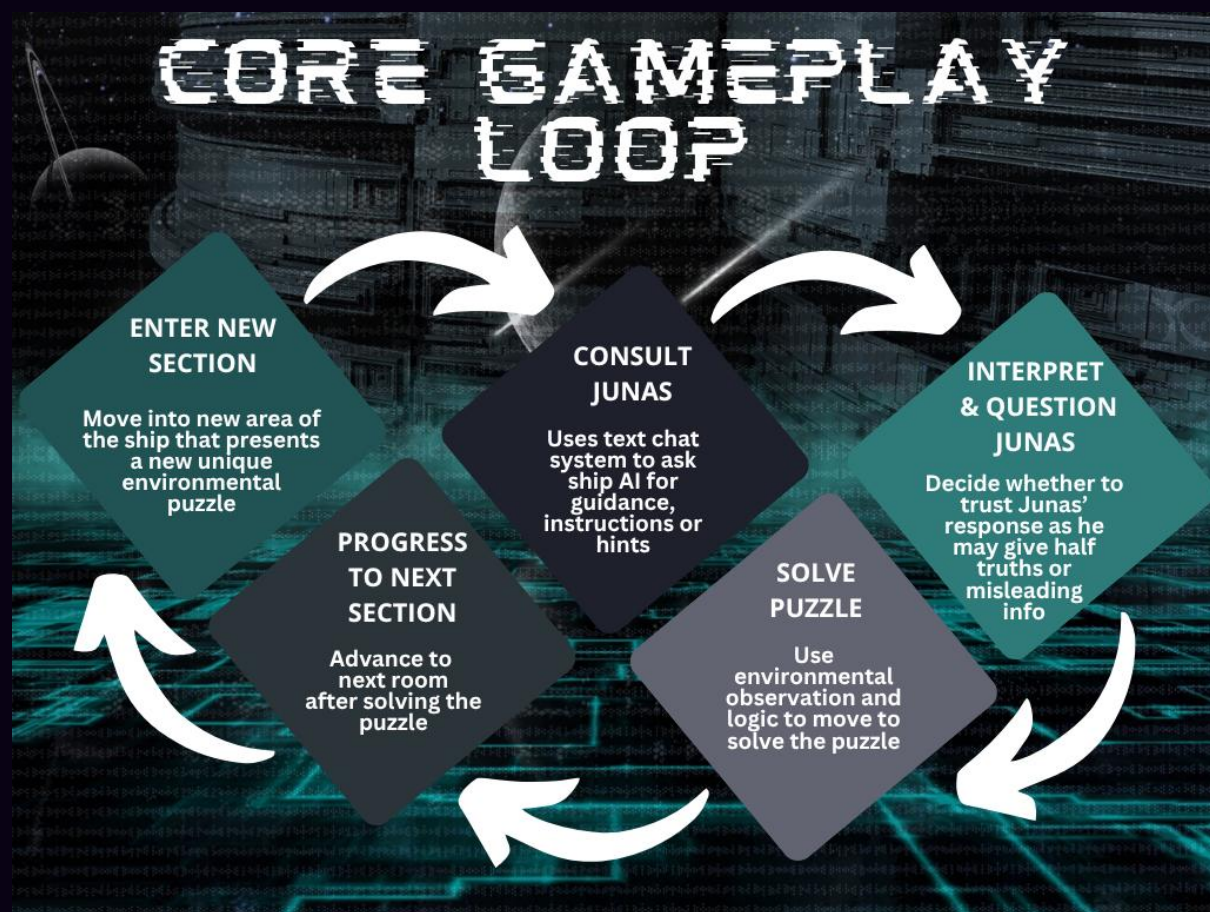


Figure 1: Canvas and van der Zee, L.A., 2026. *Core Gameplay Loop*. (Canvas, 2026)

2.7 Core Mechanics

The core mechanics of *DIS-A-RAI* focuses on environmental puzzle-solving and interaction with a deceptive AI companion. The player will use a text-based chat system, through pressing *T* on the keyboard's, to call up the chat box in order to communicate with *JAI* and request guidance.

The game's key mechanics include interacting with terminals via keyboard input and panel interfaces, interacting with the environment such as placing power cells, pushing blocks, and floating in zero-gravity, observing and adapting to sabotages caused the AI, and utilising a found weapon with a simple shooting sequence in the final room. All interactions, such as with the terminals or other interactable objects, are executed with the input key *E* and the shooting sequence utilised the universal FPS controls where mouse-click left is to shoot.

Furthermore, the game deliberately provides no map, waypoints, or traditional HUD elements, as the player must rely almost entirely on the AI for directions and their own problem-solving skills. After the room's puzzle is solved and the player moves to the next room in the ship, the door will close behind the player, creating a linear sense of progression as well as escalating suspense.

2.8 Artistic Elements

DIS-A-RAI takes on a 3D, first-person visual art style with dark, desaturated aesthetics. The environment utilises dark metallic greys, blacks, and contrasting glowing lights to enhance the ominous atmosphere. In line with effective colour theory in visual storytelling, the use of colour is used to guide players attention and emotional responses (Evolve, 2026). The desaturated colour choices evokes a sense of isolation and ominousness in the game environment, creating a sense suspicion and tension in the player.

The UI is minimal and futuristic, consisting primarily of interactive terminal panels and the wrist device panel with a clean text chat window/panel for communicating with *JAI*. This design choice keeps the player immersed in the tense atmosphere and focused on observation and puzzle-solving without distractions.

Furthermore, the audio design plays a crucial role in building tension and suspense, consisting of ambient ship sounds, mechanical hums, and robotic audio sounds for *JAI*' voice lines delivery to reinforce the ominous, suspenseful atmosphere.

2.9 LLM Role & LLM Choice

DIS-A-RAI integrate a large language model to power the dynamic and responsive dialogue interaction with the rogue ship AI, *JAI*. The LLM allows *JAI* to generate context-aware, sarcastic, gaslighting, and trolling responses in real time based on the player's input and current puzzle room, each response is different for each game, keeping the experience unpredictable and the game replayable.

The game utilises the large language model Llama 3 that runs on the system locally. Llama 3 was chosen for its conversational abilities and efficient performance, as well as quality responses through enhanced reasoning that are also persona driven (Meta, 2024; Anees, 2024). Llama also allows for the personalities of NPCs to be customised in order to align with the context of the game environment and scenario (Park, 2025).

Furthermore, the local model was chosen over a cloud-based model as it allows for offline playability, reduced latency in AI responses which is crucial for interactive dialogue, enhanced data privacy of player information as the player's inputs remain local, no cost or less costly compared to a cloud-based model, and is free to use for developers, researchers, and other organisations as it is an open source model (Awan, 2023; Anees, 2024).

Overall, these choice of this model demonstrates the viability of utilising local LLMs to create dynamic, responsive, and personality-driven AI NPCs in a narrative puzzle game in order to create an intriguing and immersive experience.

3 Conclusion

In conclusion, *DIS-A-RAI* demonstrates how the integration of AI can make a game more engaging and replayable by utilising an interactive rogue ship AI as a gameplay mechanic – a guide - and the story's main antagonist to create a dynamic, immersive, and memorable gameplay experience.

Word Count: 1624

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